

TEST LAB

The Fitness Monitor

BY ROGER COLLIER

Designed to be used at rest, the **Tinké smartphone device** measures heart rate, respiratory rate and blood oxygen to calculate fitness (Vita Index: 0-99) and heart rate variability to calculate stress (Zen Index: 0-99).

Results can be shared on social media or through the Tinké network. \$119, *shopzensorium*.



Accuracy

Can you really measure health through touch? To find out, I contact Dr. Bob McCormack, the medical director of the Canadian Olympic Committee. He doubts the device can accurately gauge respiratory rate, or variable heart rate, the basis for the Zen Index. And measuring cardio parameters simply isn't enough. You also have to look at body composition, strength and response to exercise.

Fit Test

I download the Tinké app to my iPod Touch, plug in the device, input my age and gender, and place my thumb over the flashing red light. Within seconds, my fitness score appears: 86. Not too shabby. Over the next week, I repeat the process and always get a similar number.

Zen Test

Switched to Zen mode, Tinké gives me abysmal scores, which is strange considering that I'm a pretty laid-back guy. I try the test at different times of day throughout the week, concentrating on my breathing, but can't break 50. Might be time to take a yoga class—or 10.

Second Opinion

Curious to see if I'm in as good condition as Tinké tells me, I visit TopShape Fitness Studio in Ottawa to get my stomach, thighs and other parts pinched by an expert with body fat calipers. Turns out I'm carrying almost 10 kilograms of extra fat. Suddenly, I'm not feeling so Olympian.

BEST FOR Non-athletes who want an estimate of their cardiorespiratory health while at rest.

BANG FOR YOUR BUCK Low. It's fun to compare scores with friends, but Tinké doesn't offer enough functionality to justify its price tag.